

Scientists Find New Giant Stick Insects Hiding in Plain Sight

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Stick insects are masters of disguise. Their long, thin bodies look just like twigs. Now scientists in Australia have found that some of these insects fooled experts, too.

A research team from the University of Sydney took a fresh look at large Australian stick insects in a group called Anchiale. Scientists had thought this group in Australia contained just two **species**. The team found that there are actually five. They identified two new **species** and brought back a third **species** that had gone unrecognized for decades.

The insects live from northern New South Wales, along the coast of Queensland and into tropical northern Australia. People have reported more than 1,000 sightings of them on **citizen science** websites, and scientists have studied them for years. Still, the differences had been missed.

To sort them out, researchers used DNA tests, museum **specimens**, field surveys, sightings from the public and insects raised in captivity. One large stick insect that many people knew well turned out to have been **misidentified** for decades. It is now recognized as its own **species**, Anchiale robusta.

The team also described a new **species**, Anchiale mabiensis, from the **endangered** Mabi rainforest in Queensland. Its eggs have a special lid, something never recorded before in any stick insect or its closest relatives.

"**Taxonomy** is often a bit like detective work," said lead author Dr. Braxton Jones. **Taxonomy** is the science of naming and grouping living things.

The work could help farmers and foresters, too. One stick insect that sometimes strips leaves from trees turned out to be more than one **species**. The study was published in the journal Austral Entomology.

Word Treasure

species -- A species is a group of living things that are alike and can usually have young together.

citizen science -- Citizen science is when ordinary people help researchers by sharing observations, such as photos of animals.

specimens -- Specimens are samples of plants or animals that are saved and studied, often in museums.

misidentified -- Misidentified means given the wrong name or mistaken for something else.

endangered -- Endangered means at risk of disappearing forever.

Taxonomy -- Taxonomy is the science of naming and grouping living things.

Background you need

Stick insects are plant-eating insects whose long, thin bodies help them hide by looking like twigs or branches.

Scientists group living things into species, which are kinds of organisms that share features and can usually breed with one another.

Because some species look almost the same, scientists compare DNA, museum specimens and details like eggs to tell them apart.

Australia has a huge variety of insects, and many have never been formally described by scientists.

Break it down

LEAD: Some Australian stick insects fooled experts for decades

KEY FINDING: A group thought to have two species actually has five

+ WHO: A University of Sydney team, with lead author Dr. Braxton Jones

+ WHERE: From northern New South Wales to tropical northern Australia

+ HOW: DNA tests, museum specimens, field surveys, public sightings and captive insects

DETAIL: A familiar insect is now recognized as *Anchiale robusta*

DETAIL: New species *Anchiale mabiensis* lays eggs with a never-before-recorded lid

IMPACT: Telling apart a leaf-stripping species could help farmers and foresters

Why it matters

Even well-studied insects can hide unknown species, so careful study helps scientists understand and protect nature and manage insects that affect farms and forests.

Test what you remember

1. Which university's team studied the stick insects?
 - (A) University at Buffalo
 - (B) University of Cambridge
 - (C) Harvard University
 - (D) University of Sydney
2. How many species did scientists find in the group that was thought to have two?
 - (A) Ten
 - (B) Three
 - (C) Five
 - (D) Four
3. What is special about the eggs of *Anchiale mabiensis*?
 - (A) They hatch in one day
 - (B) They have a special lid
 - (C) They are square
 - (D) They glow in the dark
4. Where does *Anchiale mabiensis* live?
 - (A) In a desert in Western Australia
 - (B) In the Mabi rainforest in Queensland
 - (C) In a city park in Sydney
 - (D) On an island near New Zealand
5. What is the new name of the familiar stick insect that had been misidentified?
 - (A) *Anchiale mabiensis*
 - (B) *Anchiale giganta*
 - (C) *Anchiale sydneyi*
 - (D) *Anchiale robusta*
6. How could the discovery help farmers and foresters?
 - (A) The insects eat other pests
 - (B) A leaf-stripping stick insect turned out to be more than one species
 - (C) Stick insects can be used as fertilizer
 - (D) It will stop all insects from eating trees

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: B

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):